

Almost overnight, Bud found himself with virtually no income. Land sales had all but stopped, and the value of his holdings fell sharply. Banks that once welcomed Bud's business were suddenly inflexible. They were unwilling to restructure short-term loans secured by his land investments. They wanted their money back and they wanted it back now. The bankers already knew what Bud was about to find out: "The rich rule over the poor, and the borrower is servant to the lender" (Proverbs 22:7).

One bank, however, did offer Bud a deal. They would restructure his loans if he would sign over his house as substitute collateral. To do this, he needed Sandi's agreement, since the house was in both their names. Bud approached Sandi that evening after their kids had gone to bed. "Sandi, I've got a problem and I need your help," Bud said timidly.

Her mind conjured up the worst circumstances imaginable. "What kind of a problem, Bud?"

"Without a second mortgage on the house, the banks won't restructure some of the loans I have on the land investments. They say the land isn't worth enough anymore. So they want me to put up the house as collateral. Now, don't worry. That doesn't mean we have to move. It's just a banking thing. Just a piece of paper."

Sandi breathed a sigh of relief, but outwardly the tough shell she had assumed as a defense stayed intact as she answered in a biting tone, "And just how much do you owe on your great investments, Bud?"

Bud winced at her tone and at the emphasis she had placed on the words *your* and *Bud*. "I don't know exactly," he lied.

"Well, give me an approximate figure. Or do you think I'm too dumb to be trusted with information like that?" Sandi said with tears coming to her eyes in spite of herself.

"You know I don't think you're dumb," Bud said with his head down.

"Well, you must. You have never once told me what you're doing. I learn more at the Christmas party when your so-called partners are